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# DRIVERS BEFORE TRUCKS

Learn the business. Build the driver pipeline.
Then buy the equipment.



# A truck is a purchase. A trucking business is a responsibility.

DRIVERS BEFORE TRUCKS

The practical guide to learning the business, recruiting drivers, and buying equipment in the right order.

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For non-CDL equipment owners, new carriers, and small fleets.

# How to use this book

Read this book before signing for a truck. If you already own one, begin with the recovery plan in Chapter 8, then work through the earlier chapters. The purpose is to replace a hopeful purchase with a business decision you can explain and support.

The sequence is simple: learn the business, define viable work, build and qualify a driver pipeline, coordinate the launch, and only then commit to equipment. Some tasks overlap. Insurance, registration, hiring, and delivery must be scheduled together. A candidate's interest is not permission to operate, and an application for authority is not active authority.

This field guide focuses on U.S. small, for-hire trucking operations using CDL-required equipment. Intrastate, non-CDL, passenger, hazardous-materials, and other specialized operations can have different requirements. A non-CDL owner means an owner who does not hold a CDL; it does not mean the truck is exempt from CDL requirements.

All financial scenarios, recruiting budgets, scripts, and case examples are illustrative. They are tools for thinking, not earnings forecasts, market quotations, contracts, or promises of success. Confirm applicable requirements and obtain professional advice for your actual operation. Source references are provided at the back.

The images are original AI-generated illustrations of fictional people and situations. They do not document actual customers, employees, trucks, or business results. This is a review edition, prepared for editorial approval before publication.

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# Introduction: The call that comes too late

"I bought a truck. Can you find me a driver?"

That question sounds like the last small item on a completed business plan. Often it is the first sign that the business plan was never finished. The owner has a payment, insurance decisions, a delivery date, and a machine that needs work. What the owner does not have is a qualified person willing to perform that work under the terms the business can afford.

There is nothing wrong with owning equipment without driving it yourself. There is something wrong with assuming that the equipment creates its own operation. Someone must recruit, qualify, schedule, supervise, pay, maintain, invoice, collect, and respond when the plan breaks. If that someone is not you, the responsibilities still need names, budgets, and oversight.

This book begins with the missing work. You will define the job before advertising it, calculate the cost before promising pay, and build a recruiting process before a vacant seat becomes an emergency. You will also learn when to stop. Sometimes the best result of recruiting is discovering that the proposed job does not work at the proposed price.

You do not need a dramatic failure statistic to take this seriously. A one-truck business with no driver has no seated truck. Its exposure is immediate and personal. The aim is to find the weak assumptions while changing them is still affordable.

CHAPTER 01

# The equipment-first trap

Owning the truck does not create the people, work, or systems needed to run it.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## The purchase feels like progress

A truck is visible. You can inspect it, photograph it, finance it, and tell people you bought it. Recruiting is less visible. It involves unanswered calls, uncomfortable questions, rejected candidates, and changes to a job you thought was attractive. Education is even less visible. Nobody applauds because you learned how to calculate deadhead or discovered that your insurance assumption was wrong.

That difference tempts owners to do the satisfying work first. They buy the truck and promise themselves they will solve the rest quickly. The purchase then changes every conversation. Instead of asking whether the operation makes sense, they ask how soon somebody can get the truck moving.

Pressure narrows judgment. An owner may accept a driver who does not fit the work, promise pay the freight cannot support, or treat a missing document as something to finish later. The payment did not create those mistakes. It made them harder to resist.

Before buying, write down what would make you walk away. Examples include an insurance quote above your modeled limit, no credible source of freight, no qualified candidate willing to accept the actual schedule, or too little cash after the down payment. Decide while you still have the freedom to decide.

## Own the responsibilities

Equipment ownership and motor-carrier operations are different roles. If you intend to lease equipment to an established carrier, understand that carrier's requirements and the written arrangement before purchasing. If you intend to operate under your own authority, understand the responsibilities you are taking on. Do not move between these models casually when the first plan gets difficult.

A dispatch service may help arrange work within its proper role. A recruiting service may introduce candidates. A maintenance shop may perform repairs. None of those services automatically makes someone responsible for your entire business.

Make a responsibility list covering hiring, driver qualification, insurance, maintenance, payroll, dispatch, safety, billing, collections, and emergencies. Put one accountable person beside each task. A vendor can perform work, but the owner needs to know what was completed, what evidence exists, and what remains open.

If you cannot name the person who answers a driver at 2 a.m., you have not finished designing the operation. If every answer is your name, include that workload in your decision. Your time is not free just because the business has not started paying you.

## A fictional first-truck purchase

Consider Dana, an equipment investor who buys a sleeper tractor because the monthly payment looks manageable. Dana expects to hire a driver for regional work and use a dispatcher to find loads. After delivery, the first interested driver wants home-daily work. The second wants a guaranteed weekly amount Dana has not budgeted. The third does not meet the insurer's requirements.

Dana now has three different problems: the job was never defined, the pay was never tested against the freight, and the insurance requirements were learned too late. Posting the same vague advertisement in more places will not repair those problems.

The better decision would have been to describe the operation first, obtain insurance guidance, model a week of work, and interview candidates about that exact job. Dana might still have purchased a truck. It might have been a different truck, for different work, at a different time.

The lesson is not that one particular type of truck is bad. It is that the truck should serve a workable operation. The operation should not be improvised to justify a truck already purchased.

## Passive income needs active scrutiny

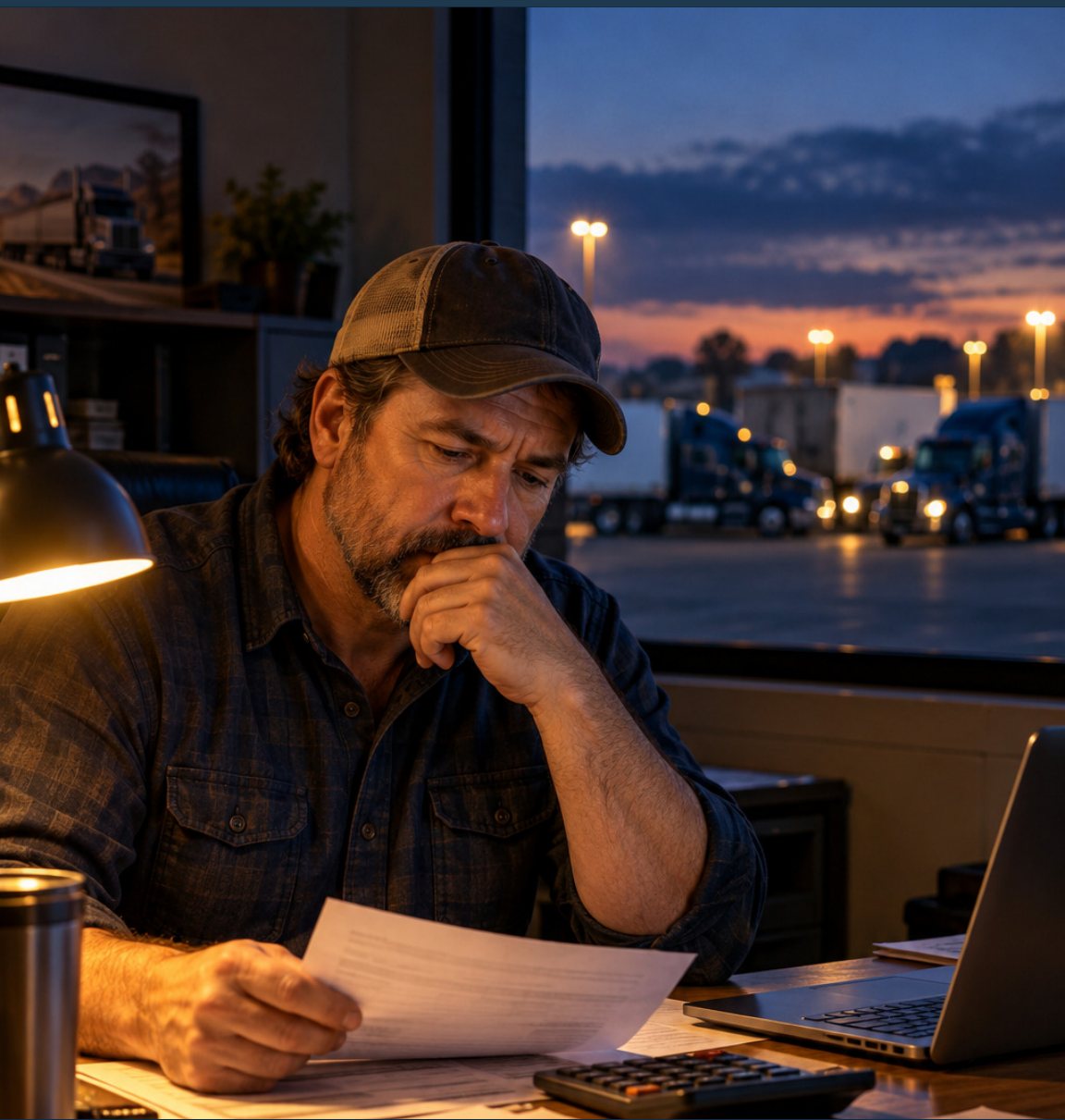
In August 2024, the FTC and Florida announced action against RivX over alleged deceptive trucking investment promises. The FTC described claims that consumers could pay $75,000 or more and receive monthly passive income from an operation managed for them. The announcement reported a court order halting operations; it described allegations, not a universal finding about trucking investments. [S1]

The practical question is who does the work and who verifies it. Ask how revenue is documented, how expenses are approved, where the truck is titled, who hires the driver, what insurance applies, and how you can review actual records. A projected monthly distribution is not a substitute for those answers.

> *Before buying equipment, prove that you understand the job the equipment must do and the people who must do it.*

# Read the evidence correctly

Serious risk deserves accurate numbers, not exaggerated ones.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## What the failure figure actually says

An August 24, 2026 FreightWaves report attributed an 85% average three-year failure rate to Kirk Mann of Mitsubishi HC Capital for carriers with fewer than two years of operating experience and their own authority during the prolonged downturn. That is a reported observation about a particular group and period. The short report does not supply enough methodology to treat it as the probability that any new trucking company will fail. [S2]

It also does not establish that buying before recruiting caused every failure. Financing, freight rates, repairs, cash reserves, and management can interact. This book uses the observation as context for caution, not as proof that 85% or 90% of all new carriers fail within two years.

Be equally careful with authority counts. An authority revocation is not automatically a bankruptcy. A business may close voluntarily, change structure, suspend operations, or lose registration for another reason. Counts with different definitions should not be combined into a more alarming statistic.

The actionable question is smaller: what would cause your business to run out of cash, lose its driver, or become unable to operate? Answer that with your own numbers and documents. A national percentage cannot do it for you.

## Use benchmarks as questions

ATRI's July 2025 release reported average truck operating costs of $2.260 per mile for 2024. This is a dated benchmark, not a quotation for your proposed truck or the latest possible cost reading. It shows why an owner needs a detailed model rather than a fuel-and-payment estimate. [S3]

Your costs can differ because of equipment condition, insurance history, freight type, driver compensation, geography, financing, utilization, and purchasing power. A paid-off truck still needs repairs and eventual replacement. An inexpensive truck may carry expensive downtime. A higher-priced unit may still be the wrong equipment for the job.

Use a benchmark to find missing categories. If your model is far below a broad industry figure, ask what you left out. Owner labor? Benefits? Empty miles? Tolls? Repair reserves? If your model is higher, investigate rather than assuming customers will pay the difference.

The financial examples in this book are constructed teaching scenarios. They are not ATRI tables and should not be presented as average fleet results. That distinction lets you change the assumptions honestly instead of treating an example as authority.

## The market does not owe you a payment

A loan can be approved while a business plan remains weak. Financing asks whether a lender is willing to provide money on specified terms. It does not establish that your freight, driver, insurance, and operating costs will produce a margin.

Stress-test the operation before admiring the best week. Reduce loaded miles, increase empty miles, delay a payment, add a repair, or remove the driver for several weeks. Then look at the lowest projected cash balance. If one ordinary disruption forces you to miss payroll or maintenance, the launch plan is too fragile.

Do not assume a resale price will rescue the plan. Equipment values change, and a sale can take time. Obtain a current payoff amount and realistic sale estimates before relying on an exit. Loan default, repossession, cure rights, and any remaining debt depend on the agreement and applicable law; there is no universal 30- or 60-day repossession calendar suitable for every reader.

That is why the book does not reproduce a dramatic default countdown. Your actual contract matters more than a generic timeline. Read it before signing and obtain qualified advice about terms you do not understand.

## Registration is a starting requirement

FMCSA lists a $300 fee for each type of permanent operating authority sought. That is an application fee, not the price of becoming a competent or fully ready carrier. Authority requirements depend on the operation, and a USDOT number and operating authority serve different purposes. [S4]

New entrants also face oversight. FMCSA describes an initial 18-month monitoring period and a safety audit generally within 12 months after beginning operations for the property-carrier context addressed here. An unsuccessful audit is not accurately described as immediate permanent revocation in every case. The applicable process and corrective actions matter. [S5]

The owner's standard should exceed "I submitted the forms." It should be: "I can show how the operation will comply, who maintains the records, and how the business pays its bills."

## Your evidence rule

For each important assumption, record its source and date. Use a current written insurance quote for insurance, a proposed agreement for financing, real lane information for freight, and candidate conversations for recruiting. Mark estimates as estimates. If you cannot identify where a number came from, do not use it to justify a purchase.

# Invest in knowledge first

Learn enough to recognize a bad decision before it becomes an expensive obligation.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## Build a learning plan with outputs

Reading is useful when it changes a decision. Organize your preparation around documents you can produce: a cost model, a cash forecast, a clear job description, an insurance question list, and a compliance responsibility calendar. These are more useful than saying you watched ten videos.

Use Freight University at freightuniversity.online as the starting point identified for this book. Look for available lessons and library material on carrier operations, cost per mile, fraud prevention, and business fundamentals. This edition does not claim that a specific course or module is currently available. Pair educational material with the official sources listed at the back.

For each topic, explain it in plain language to another person. What costs continue when the truck stops? How will the driver be paid? What makes a load unprofitable? Who can authorize dispatch? What happens if the customer pays late? If the explanation collapses into "the dispatcher handles it," keep learning.

Education does not mean becoming your own attorney, accountant, mechanic, and insurance broker. It means knowing enough to ask them useful questions, understand their answers, and recognize when a decision needs their help.

## Calculate on all miles

Suppose a planned month includes 8,000 loaded miles and 2,000 empty miles. The truck travels 10,000 total miles. In this fictional model, variable cash operating costs are $1.25 per total mile and monthly fixed cash obligations are $5,000.

Variable outflow is 10,000 x $1.25 = $12,500. Add $5,000 and the modeled monthly cash outflow is $17,500. Divided by all miles, that is $1.75 per total mile. Divided by loaded miles, it requires $2.1875 per loaded mile just to cover those modeled outflows.

At $2.40 per loaded mile, gross revenue would be $19,200. The difference is $1,700 before any costs omitted from the model, taxes, owner distributions, and further reserves. Calling $2.40 minus $1.75 a

$0.65 profit on every loaded mile would mix two different mileage bases.

Check what the rate includes. Fuel surcharge, detention, stop pay, accessorials, factoring charges, and deductions can change the result. Do not count an accessorial as collected cash just because you submitted a request for it.

## Keep cash and profit distinct

The example above is a cash-planning model. Loan principal is a cash outflow, but it is not the same thing as an accounting expense. Depreciation is an accounting allocation that does not usually require a separate cash payment that day. Ask your accountant to help you maintain both views.

For purchase decisions, the cash view answers whether you can meet obligations on time. The profit view helps assess whether the business earns an adequate return after its economic costs. Mixing full loan payments and depreciation without explanation can double-count part of equipment cost. Ignoring replacement needs because the truck is paid off creates the opposite error.

Also distinguish owner wages from owner profit. If you recruit, dispatch, reconcile pay, and handle collections without charging anything for that work, the operation may be buying your labor cheaply rather than producing a strong return. Put a reasonable owner-compensation assumption in your long-term model, even if launch cash planning temporarily differs.

## Plan for the payment gap

Imagine $4,000 of weekly cash outflow and six weeks between starting work and receiving the first usable customer payment. The simple bridge is $24,000. Then add startup outlays and a disruption allowance, subtract only reliable cash inflows, and test the calendar week by week.

Six weeks is a scenario, not a claim about every broker or shipper. Read the actual payment terms, document requirements, dispute procedures,

and any financing arrangement. An invoice missing its proof of delivery can sit longer than the stated payment period.

A cash forecast should show opening cash, receipts, payroll, fuel, repairs, fixed obligations, other payments, and closing cash. The lowest closing balance matters more than the month's total revenue. A profitable-looking month can still contain a payroll crisis.

Keep reserve categories visible. Money reserved for a likely repair should not also be counted as the insurance down payment and the recruiting budget. One dollar cannot protect three risks at the same time.

## Ask insurance questions early

Describe the actual operation to the insurance professional: equipment, freight, territory, authority status, experience, anticipated drivers, and any special work. Ask what would make a driver unacceptable, what information is needed for approval, and whether a substitution changes the quote.

Get written clarification of coverage, limits, deductibles, exclusions, payment schedule, and effective dates. Confirm whether your planned customers or contracting carrier impose additional requirements. A preliminary indication is not the same as coverage in force for the truck, driver, and operation you eventually choose.

Use this information to design lawful, job-related recruiting criteria. Do not spend weeks attracting applicants the actual operation cannot accommodate. Equally, do not advertise guessed insurer requirements as federal law. Keep legal requirements, insurer conditions, and your own preferences clearly separated.

## Learn the safety basics before scheduling

FMCSA's property-carrier hours-of-service summary describes limits including up to 11 hours of driving after 10 consecutive hours off duty, a 14-hour driving window, and applicable 60/70-hour limits. Break rules and exceptions also matter. These limits are not a promise that every route can use every available hour. [S6]

Plan for loading, inspections, traffic, parking, weather, and home time. A rate that works only if a driver ignores limits is not a workable rate. Learn the requirements for your operation, then have a qualified person review the first schedules.

Your knowledge checkpoint is practical: produce one realistic week, including all miles and duty time, and explain how the driver gets paid, the bills get paid, and the driver gets home.

CHAPTER 04

# The driver reality and the empty seat

The relevant labor market is the one willing and qualified to do your actual job.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## Stop asking only whether drivers exist

There may be many CDL holders in a region and very few who want your schedule, can meet the applicable requirements, live within a workable distance, and will accept your compensation. That is the recruiting market you need to understand.

Define the position before searching. Local, regional, and over-the-road work create different lives. A driver returning to the terminal at midnight is not receiving the same home-time arrangement as a driver finishing each afternoon. A five-day trip with an unpredictable return is not the same as a predictable weekly route.

Ask candidates what they need rather than assuming every driver wants the same thing. Some prioritize steady earnings. Others need a certain schedule, equipment configuration, or freight type. Treat those differences as information about fit. A qualified driver can reasonably reject a job that does not fit their life.

The goal is not to persuade everyone. It is to identify a small number of people whose needs match work you can honestly provide. Recruiting becomes easier when you stop describing a generic opportunity and start describing a real job.

## Calculate the cash cost of waiting

Use a simple illustrative parked-truck budget: $3,000 monthly equipment payments, $1,200 insurance cash outflow, $300 parking, and $300 for other continuing commitments. Total: $4,800 per month. Using a 30-day planning month, the daily cash burn is $160.

Ten days costs $1,600; 21 days costs $3,360; 30 days costs $4,800. Those figures exclude any additional repair, recruiting, storage, or startup spending. They also exclude depreciation and possible foregone earnings. Replace every input with your actual obligations.

Insurance payments and coverage needs may change under particular arrangements, but do not cancel or reduce coverage on your own assumption that a parked truck has no exposure. Coordinate with the insurer and lender. Likewise, parking the vehicle does not automatically pause financing or other commitments.

This calculation gives you something useful: the cash cost of delay. It does not tell you that accepting an unsuitable driver is cheaper. A hurried hire can introduce much larger operational problems.

## Lost revenue is not lost profit

Assume a fictional operating day could produce $900 in revenue and would require $650 of avoidable operating outflow. The contribution toward fixed costs and profit is $250. If the day never happens, the foregone contribution is $250, not the full $900.

Using the earlier $160 daily fixed cash cost, an operating day would leave $90 after those modeled costs. An idle day would consume $160. The difference between the two is $250. Adding $160 of fixed costs to $900 of lost revenue and calling the result the business's loss confuses categories.

You may track continuing cash burn and foregone contribution separately because they answer different questions. Do not add them into a headline without defining the comparison. If there was no realistic load available, even the $250 opportunity assumption may be unsupported.

The business needs honest numbers most when it feels urgent. Overstated loss estimates can push an owner into a bad hire, unnecessary advertising, or an expensive vendor agreement that the evidence does not justify.

## A pipeline is a set of stages

An inquiry is someone who responded. A contacted prospect is someone you actually reached. A screened prospect appears to fit the basic job criteria. A formal applicant has provided the required application information. A candidate in qualification still has checks or approvals outstanding. A driver released for dispatch has passed the operation's required release process.

Those stages are not interchangeable. Twenty messages do not mean twenty available drivers. Two promising interviews do not mean two

qualified hires. Keep the stage and next action beside each name so optimism cannot hide unfinished work.

Aim to have a credible primary candidate and a consented backup contact before an irreversible equipment commitment, where timing and the actual hiring process permit. This is a planning recommendation, not a legal rule or a guarantee that candidates will wait. Do not ask people to resign from existing work on the strength of a speculative launch.

## Test the job before the purchase

Set a defined recruiting test, such as two weeks, with a stated budget and a review date. Tell prospects if the operation is preparing to launch and give an honest expected timeframe. Use platforms only in ways their current rules permit; do not advertise a job as immediately available when it is not.

At the review, ask how many people were reached, how many fit, why others declined, and what remains uncertain. If good candidates consistently reject the schedule or pay, change the business plan before changing the truck payment from hypothetical to real.

# Build your own driver pipeline

A small operator needs a repeatable process, not a desperate advertisement.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## Start with a job worth describing

Write a one-page job brief before creating an advertisement. State the terminal or home base, freight and equipment, operating territory, schedule, home-time arrangement, compensation method, benefits actually offered, and relevant qualifications. Explain whether the role involves touching freight, overnight travel, weekends, or specialized duties.

Compensation needs a calculation. If pay is per mile, identify the mileage basis and how empty miles are treated. If it is a percentage, define the revenue base and exclusions. If you show a weekly range, explain the assumptions and whether anything is guaranteed. Have the final wording checked against applicable pay-transparency and wage requirements.

An honest brief may attract fewer people than a broad promise. That can be progress. You want candidates who understand the work and still want the conversation. The wrong volume consumes time and hides the reasons suitable people are declining.

Do not use stock or generated photographs to imply that you already own a particular truck. Show actual equipment when available, or label illustrative images. Trust starts before the first interview.

## A model advertisement

The following is a fictional example, not a live offer. Replace every detail with verified terms before using it.

> *Class A regional dry-van driver | Columbus, Ohio base. Planned Monday-Friday regional work, with overnight trips and a target Friday return. Launch date will be confirmed before a start commitment. Example pay: $0.65 per paid mile on the stated mileage system; loaded and empty dispatched miles included. At 2,200 paid miles, mileage pay would be $1,430 before taxes. Miles and weekly earnings are not guaranteed. Detention, layover, benefits, and other terms will be explained in writing. Contact the named hiring manager for the complete job description and qualification process.*

This example exposes questions instead of hiding them. What is the mileage system? What happens during a slow week? What is paid during orientation? Can the company actually return the driver on Friday? A final advertisement needs answers consistent with the operation and local requirements.

Avoid "up to" earnings that only the best imaginable week could produce. Explain normal work using defensible assumptions. The driver should not discover the real job after leaving another employer.

## Start with three channels

For a first test, choose one broad job board, one local or public-workforce route, and one relationship-based channel. That is enough to learn whether the job attracts suitable candidates without scattering a tiny budget across ten places.

Ask every prospect how they found you. Use a short channel label in your tracker. If the same person appears through several channels, count that person once while retaining the source history. Duplicates can make a weak campaign appear productive.

Do not declare a universal winner after one hire. Small samples are noisy. Compare fit, responsiveness, screening progress, actual starts, and retention as evidence accumulates. A channel that produces fewer leads may still produce better conversations.

## Indeed: buy a measured test

Indeed offers free and sponsored posting options, with availability and pricing depending on its current rules and the account or market. Its employer guidance describes charging models based on clicks or started applications. Check the actual dashboard terms before authorizing spend; a fixed $5 or $15 daily minimum should not be assumed. [S7]

Prepare the job brief, business identity, contact information, and response coverage first. Then review the posting preview, screening questions, location, billing method, budget controls, and cancellation or pause behavior. Confirm who will check applications each day.

For teaching purposes, an owner might cap a test at $150 over ten days if the platform permits that setup. That is a planning example, not a price quotation or recommendation that every market can be tested adequately for that amount. Keep a separate record of actual charges.

Review results while the test is running. If applicants repeatedly misunderstand home time, fix the description. If qualified prospects do not answer, examine contact timing and your employer identity. If nobody suitable applies, investigate the job and the channel before raising the budget.

## Facebook groups and social advertising

Find groups relevant to the actual home base, equipment, or work. Read their rules and obtain administrator approval where required. A concise, local, specific post is more useful than copying a vague advertisement into dozens of groups.

Identify the business and the hiring contact. Put schedule and compensation information where people can see it. Invite a private conversation, but do not request a CDL image, Social Security number, medical information, or other sensitive records in a public comment thread.

Paid social advertising requires a second check: the platform's current employment-ad policies and targeting restrictions. Use the required employment category where applicable. Do not design exclusionary

targeting around protected traits or assume an old advertising tutorial is still accurate.

Set a total test budget and a review date. Track qualified conversations, not likes. A post may receive attention because it starts an argument; attention alone is not recruiting performance.

## State workforce offices and local boards

Contact the state employment service or a local American Job Center and ask about employer job-listing services, candidate referrals, and hiring events. Confirm eligibility, current costs, and the process directly. Explain the actual job and experience requirements rather than asking for "anyone with a CDL."

Workforce or training funding may help eligible people, but it is not a blanket promise of free drivers or free training for every business. Ask how referrals are prepared and what the employer is expected to provide.

Local newspapers, community publications, and permitted bulletin boards can be worth testing for geographically specific work. Ask the publisher about circulation and the board owner about permission. Truck-stop locations set their own posting rules; do not assume a national chain permits flyers everywhere.

Keep the local advertisement short: job, base, schedule, pay structure, key qualifications, and one contact method. Use a readable phone number even when you include a QR code. A person should not need to install an app to ask about the job.

## Specialized boards and schools

CDL-focused boards may help reach drivers already looking for trucking work. Compare written prices, contract length, renewal terms, applicant access, cancellation, and what the service actually delivers. A posting package, a lead service, and a placement agreement are different purchases.

CDL schools are appropriate partners only if your operation can responsibly hire and develop newer drivers. Confirm insurance

acceptance, supervision, training capacity, equipment suitability, and the actual work. A one-truck owner without training capacity should not treat a school as an instant substitute for experience.

FMCSA's ELDT rules apply to specified first-time CDL, upgrade, and endorsement applicants, subject to exceptions and prior-license provisions. The training framework does not mean every licensed driver needs new ELDT, and it does not establish readiness for your particular operation. [S8]

## Respond like the job matters

Set a service standard you can keep: for example, a personal response within two business hours during published recruiting hours. This is a suggested operating practice, not a measured industry threshold. Assign backup coverage when you are unavailable.

Start simply: "Thanks for contacting us about the regional role. Is this a safe time to talk, or are you driving? I would like to explain the schedule and pay, then hear what you are looking for." Never pressure a driver to read messages, complete forms, or interview while driving.

After the conversation, send the agreed next step through the candidate's preferred, permitted channel. If there is no response, use a modest follow-up schedule and stop when asked. Keep contact permission and the last contact date. Persistence should be professional, not intrusive.

## Spend against outcomes

Suppose a fictional campaign costs $300 and produces 30 unique inquiries, 12 conversations, six basic fits, three applicants, and one start. Cost per inquiry is $10; cost per basic fit is $50; advertising cost per start is $300. These are different measures.

Add screening fees, paid orientation, owner time, travel reimbursements, and any placement fee to calculate a fuller hiring cost. Track vacancy cash burn separately so it does not get counted twice. Later, calculate cost per driver still employed at 90 days, using only hires old enough to reach that point.

An agency can make sense when its service solves a defined problem at a justified price. Obtain a written quote, replacement conditions, refund terms, and clarity about screening responsibilities. This book favors building an owned pipeline; it does not claim every agency is unnecessary or that a fee automatically makes a business unprofitable.

## Run a weekly recruiting review

Look at the funnel once a week. Where are candidates stopping? Are calls unanswered, expectations mismatched, applications incomplete, or qualifications unresolved? Fix the stage with evidence of a problem.

Keep one owner for each next action and a due date. Recruiting becomes manageable when every prospect has a status. It becomes expensive when the entire process lives in scattered messages and somebody's memory.

# Screen carefully and make the first hire

Interest is the beginning of a process. It is not authorization to dispatch.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## Separate fit from qualification

The first conversation establishes whether the work and expectations appear compatible. It does not establish legal qualification. Ask about relevant equipment and freight experience, schedule needs, location, and availability. Explain the job before asking someone to invest time in a formal process.

Use consistent, job-related questions. "Tell me how you handle a delivery appointment you cannot safely reach" is more useful than an impression based on friendliness. Ask for examples of reporting defects, communicating delays, resolving pay questions, and planning parking.

Listen for practical judgment, then verify the matters that require records. A confident answer is not evidence that a license is valid or that an insurer accepts the driver. A quiet candidate is not automatically a poor driver. Keep interview notes factual and relevant.

## Use a current application

For covered drivers, 49 CFR 391.21 specifies application information, including employment history. The additional seven years of relevant commercial-driving history for specified CMV applicants is not an age-based rule that begins when a driver turns 23. Use a current, compliant application rather than the age-based shortcut sometimes repeated online. [S9]

Identify who reviews completeness and follows up on gaps. Explain how the information will be used and provide a secure submission method. Do not use this book's recruiting tracker as a substitute for the formal application or driver qualification file.

Your initial inquiry form can be short. The formal application and qualification process cannot be replaced by a few social-media answers. Keep the distinction visible so a convenient first step does not become the entire hiring process.

## Qualification records and inquiries

For covered operations, review the license class, endorsements and restrictions, medical qualification requirements, driving record, safety-performance history, and road-test requirements or permitted equivalents. Confirm the current rules for the driver and operation, including electronic medical-certification processes where applicable. [S10, S11]

Section 391.23 generally calls for inquiries to states where the driver held a license during the preceding three years, not merely the preceding 30 days. Required investigations have specified timing, including a 30-day employment-start window for certain inquiries. A carrier can adopt an earlier verification practice; it should not confuse that practice with the wording of every federal deadline. [S10]

Keep an organized qualification file with a named reviewer and renewal calendar. Section 391.51 identifies required file materials and retention rules, including distinctions between the overall file and records that may be removed after specified periods. Do not apply one universal retention period to every record. [S11]

Include the required annual driving-record inquiry and documented annual review in that calendar. For CDL drivers, obtain the appropriate licensing-state medical-status record under the current process rather than assuming a paper medical card alone completes the file. [S11]

For daily management, use an evidence index: item, source, date obtained, reviewer, location, and next review date. The index helps find evidence; it is not the evidence itself. Sensitive records need controlled access, not a shared recruiting spreadsheet.

## PSP is an additional tool

FMCSA's Pre-Employment Screening Program is voluntary for carriers and drivers. It provides safety-history information for pre-employment use, with required authorization. It does not replace the motor vehicle record, other required inquiries, or the employer's judgment. [S12]

Do not describe a driver's PSP as a pass/fail license or assume a listed crash proves fault. Review the record in context and follow the

applicable process for using consumer information. Explain the screening process consistently to candidates.

## Clearinghouse and testing are separate

For drivers subject to the applicable FMCSA drug-and-alcohol rules, the employer must conduct the required pre-employment full Clearinghouse query with the driver's electronic consent. Current drivers also require at least annual queries; an annual query may be limited or full as permitted. A limited query showing information requires timely full-query follow-up. A prohibited status prevents covered safety-sensitive work. [S13]

A query is not a drug test. For covered new hires, arrange the required pre-employment controlled-substances testing and receive the verified negative result before operating, unless a specific regulatory exception has been properly established. Do not assume an old test result qualifies for an exception. A delayed start can also require reassessment of testing and program status. [S14]

Have a qualified program administrator establish the ongoing testing program and required records. Keep restricted testing information appropriately controlled. A recruiting assistant needs to know whether the candidate can proceed, not every confidential detail behind that status.

## Fair decisions and candidate privacy

When using third-party consumer reports for employment, applicable federal requirements include disclosure, authorization, and adverse-action procedures. FTC guidance explains the general process, including providing report information before certain negative decisions. State and local requirements and trucking-specific provisions can affect the details. Use an appropriate current process rather than improvising a rejection message. [S15]

Avoid collecting sensitive information through ordinary text messages or public forms without proper controls. Limit access, use legitimate providers, establish retention and disposal practices, and keep applicant records out of marketing lists.

An inconsistency should trigger clarification and verification. A confirmed disqualification should trigger the applicable decision process. Neither should trigger gossip, public accusations, or casual sharing of a person's record.

## Make a conditional offer honestly

Discuss the written job terms, anticipated start date, remaining checks, equipment availability, and launch dependencies. Describe contingencies plainly. This book does not supply an employment agreement; use an offer process appropriate to your jurisdiction and business.

If your launch slips, tell the candidate promptly. Do not leave a person waiting indefinitely while you negotiate equipment. Keep backup contacts informed without implying that multiple people have been promised the same immediate job.

Before dispatch, conduct a documented release review with the responsible safety person: driver qualification, applicable testing and query status, insurer acceptance, equipment readiness, required operating permissions, and orientation. Any unresolved prerequisite is a hold. A customer waiting on freight does not change that decision.

## Teach the actual first day

Orientation should cover pay examples, dispatch communication, hours reporting, defect reporting, breakdown help, accident procedures, cargo documents, fuel access, and escalation contacts. Have the driver explain key steps back to you and demonstrate the systems they will use.

A signature proves that something was signed. It does not prove that the driver understood your workflow. Walk through a delay, a defect, and a pay discrepancy before those situations become urgent. The first hire should leave knowing how to get help and confident that reporting a safety concern will be taken seriously.

# Keep the pipeline alive

Retention begins when the job you deliver matches the job you described.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## The first week is an audit of your promises

A new driver is comparing the advertisement with the actual operation. Is the truck ready? Is the dispatcher reachable? Are the miles calculated as explained? Does the first pay statement make sense? Small disappointments can reveal a larger gap between the sales pitch and the job.

Check in after the first trip and after the first payroll. Ask three concrete questions: What was different from what we described? What made the work harder than necessary? What needs an answer before the next trip? Write down the response and the person responsible for follow-through.

Do not promise a repair, pay correction, or schedule change simply to end an uncomfortable conversation. Give a realistic next step and report back. Reliability is built through completed commitments, including small ones.

## Protect the basics

Accurate pay, workable schedules, maintained equipment, and respectful communication are operating disciplines. They cannot be replaced with a recruiting slogan. If you promise predictable home time, build dispatch decisions around it and explain exceptions honestly before they become routine.

Use a maintenance reporting process with acknowledgment and closure. A driver should know whether a defect has been evaluated and what happens next. A safety concern is not a test of loyalty. Do not pressure drivers to operate equipment that should be held for inspection or repair.

When the freight plan changes, revisit the job. A driver hired for regional work may not want extended over-the-road trips. Treat that as a change to discuss, not a failure of attitude. If the business cannot deliver its original promise, recruiting copy should change too.

## Design a referral program you can afford

Once drivers understand and trust the operation, invite referrals. Explain that referred applicants receive the same qualification review as everyone else. Friendship is not a waiver of standards.

An illustrative program might offer $600, with $200 after the referred driver starts and $400 after 90 days, subject to clearly written eligibility terms. The amount and timing are examples, not market benchmarks. Review the terms, payroll treatment, and applicable rules before using them.

Explain who can refer, how a referral is recorded, what happens with duplicate referrals, and when earned payments are made. Avoid vague conditions that allow the owner to change the deal after the referral succeeds. Do not make drivers pay recruiting fees or conceal unfavorable job details to earn a bonus.

Track the cost and outcome. A referral program should earn its place through suitable hires and a fair experience, not through assumptions that referred drivers always stay longer.

## Stay in touch without pretending to hire

Maintain a permission-based list of people who would welcome future contact. Record their preferred work, contact method, and last conversation date. Ask whether they want an update when a suitable opening exists. Respect a request to stop.

If there is no vacancy, say so. Do not run an immediate-start advertisement simply to collect names. A truthful interest list can support continuity without wasting candidates' time.

Check the pipeline at a sensible interval. People move, change jobs, gain experience, or no longer want the schedule. An old name is not a ready replacement. When an opening becomes real, re-establish interest and complete the required current qualification process.

## Measure retention fairly

For a small fleet, individual departures can swing percentages sharply. Record starts and departures, length of service, job, source, and the stated reason for leaving. Separate voluntary departure, employer decision, and other circumstances where appropriate.

For a 90-day retention measure, count only drivers who have had time to reach 90 days. If three people started last week, they do not belong in the completed 90-day denominator. Keep both the count and the percentage so the sample size stays visible.

Look for patterns you can act on. Repeated complaints about pay calculation require a pay-process review. Repeated departures after route changes require a job-design review. A new advertisement will not repair a recurring operating problem.

## Plan a professional departure

Create a clear process for returning equipment, keys, access devices, and business records; arranging safe vehicle recovery; handling final pay appropriately; and updating systems. Coordinate responsibilities without threats or improvised deductions.

Ask what could have been better, but do not require a departing driver to agree with your interpretation. The aim is to protect people and equipment, settle the process properly, and learn enough to reduce avoidable repeat problems.

> *A living pipeline is useful. A business that keeps its promises makes that pipeline less expensive to maintain.*

CHAPTER 08

# Make the purchase decision

Readiness is evidence you can review, not a date you feel pressured to meet.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

## Coordinate the launch instead of reversing the lesson

The sequence in this book does not mean every registration, quote, or hiring step waits until a driver is fully hired. Some prerequisites must be developed together. The point is to resolve the major uncertainties before accepting irreversible equipment costs.

Use three decisions: Is the operation viable? Is the launch sufficiently prepared to commit? Is the specific driver and truck authorized and ready to dispatch? Passing the first does not automatically pass the other two.

For viability, review freight, all-mile economics, cash needs, and the actual job. For commitment, review equipment condition, financing, insurance, candidate evidence, timing, and fallback plans. For dispatch, verify completed operational and safety prerequisites. Keep these decisions separate in your records.

## A suggested 30-60 day preparation plan

Days 1-10: define the business model and target work. Complete the learning outputs, obtain preliminary insurance guidance, identify registration and safety responsibilities, and build the first cash forecast. Do not treat the calendar as a deadline to buy.

Days 11-25: test the job through truthful recruiting. Track inquiries, conversations, fit, and objections. Investigate equipment options without assuming you must select one. Improve the pay and schedule model using what you learn.

Days 26-40: move suitable candidates through the appropriate formal process, coordinate launch prerequisites, obtain written equipment and financing information, and investigate any unresolved costs. Have the relevant advisers review the actual plan.

Days 41-60: make the commitment decision only if the evidence supports it. Coordinate delivery, coverage, qualification, orientation, and first work. Extend the schedule when approvals, candidates, or

economics are not ready. This is an illustrative planning rhythm, not a prediction of agency processing times or hiring speed.

## Inspect the equipment as a business input

Match specifications to freight, routes, parking, maintenance support, and the driver's work. Arrange a competent independent inspection and review available maintenance history. Understand warranty terms, exclusions, and the practical process for getting work performed.

Price the whole acquisition: down payment, financing obligations, taxes and fees, transport, immediate repairs, tires, required equipment, insurance outlays, and time before service. A purchase price is only one line of that total.

Do not spend the repair reserve on cosmetic improvements before basic readiness is established. Do not assume a newly purchased truck is ready merely because it starts and moves. The person approving the purchase and the person approving it for service may need different expertise.

## Give uncertainty a stop rule

Write a minimum cash balance below which you will not launch, a maximum unresolved exposure you will accept, and a date for reviewing stale candidate interest. Use actual amounts from your plan; this book cannot select them for you.

If the primary candidate withdraws, revisit the commitment decision. If the insurer changes the terms, rerun the model. If the equipment inspection reveals a major repair, revise both cost and timing. These are changes in the decision, not inconveniences to hide.

Do not average away a failed prerequisite. Strong advertising results do not compensate for inadequate cash. A low truck price does not compensate for an unsuitable driver. One critical failure can be enough to hold the launch.

## If you already bought the truck

Begin with facts, not blame. List the truck's location and condition, current coverage, payment dates, storage obligations, available cash, and any written agreements. Identify the responsible person for securing and maintaining the asset while you reassess.

Then complete the job brief, insurance review, cost model, and recruiting test. Keep qualification standards intact. Urgency can justify assigning more management attention; it does not justify skipping required checks.

Contact the lender or other counterparties early if you anticipate difficulty. Ask what options exist and obtain any agreement in writing. Do not assume an informal conversation changes payment duties or prevents enforcement. Seek qualified advice about contracts and possible exits.

Compare realistic paths: hold while rebuilding the plan, arrange an appropriate lawful lease or operating relationship, sell, or pursue another documented option. Evaluate costs, restrictions, timing, and risks. If the vehicle must be moved, use an appropriately qualified and insured provider for that specific move. Do not dispatch an unqualified applicant merely to relocate the truck.

## The next truck must pass the same test

One successful hire is not evidence that the second truck will fill itself. Expansion changes cash exposure and management workload. Reuse the same readiness process for every additional unit.

Ask whether your current driver is receiving accurate pay, equipment issues are closed, and the recruiting tracker is current. If the first operation is unstable, another truck can multiply the instability. Growth should follow a repeatable process, not the excitement of the first revenue deposit.

## The decision you are trying to earn

You are ready to consider equipment when you can explain the work, defend the numbers, identify the people, show the required preparation, and survive a reasonable disruption. You are ready to dispatch only when the actual operating requirements are met.

Knowledge first. A credible driver pipeline next. Equipment committed through a coordinated, evidence-based launch. Keep that order when the deal looks attractive, when a seller creates urgency, and when somebody says the driver will be easy to find.

The truck can wait for a sound decision. Your cash reserve may not survive a bad one.

# Worksheet 1 | The job you are actually offering

Complete this before writing an advertisement. Use specific terms a candidate can evaluate. An unresolved field is a question to answer, not a detail to hide.

Business model and accountable hiring manager

Home base, operating area, and freight type

Equipment and specialized duties

Normal schedule, overnight work, and home-time arrangement

Pay method, mileage or revenue basis, and example calculation

Detention, layover, orientation, and other pay terms

Benefits actually available and eligibility conditions

Legal requirements, insurer conditions, and employer preferences

Expected start window and unresolved launch dependencies

# Worksheet 2 | Empty-seat cash budget

Use continuing cash outflows only. Keep depreciation and foregone contribution separate. Divide by a stated planning period; do not quietly change between calendar days and operating days.

Monthly truck and trailer payments

Monthly insurance cash outflow while parked, confirmed with insurer

Parking, storage, and other continuing commitments

Total monthly continuing cash outflow

Planning days per month and cash burn per day

Cash cost of a 10-day vacancy

Cash cost of a 21-day vacancy

Additional one-time recruiting or repair cash needs

Available reserve after other committed uses

# Worksheet 3 | Recruiting funnel review

Use one row per unique candidate in your own tracker. Keep sensitive records in the appropriate protected system. This page is a weekly summary, not a driver qualification file.

Review week, responsible person, and channels used

Spend by channel and total actual charges

Unique inquiries / contacted prospects / basic fits

Applications / qualification in progress / cleared starts

Main reasons suitable prospects declined

Oldest unresolved next action and its owner

Cost per basic fit and advertising cost per start

Change to test next week and review date

Candidates who consented to future contact

# Worksheet 4 | Qualification and dispatch release

Use with the current requirements for your operation and a qualified reviewer. This is a management index, not an exhaustive legal checklist. Record the evidence location, reviewer, and completion or due date for each applicable item.

Formal application and employment-history review

License, endorsements, restrictions, and medical qualification

Required driving-record and safety-history inquiries

Road test or permitted equivalent; role-specific readiness

Applicable Clearinghouse full query and testing prerequisites

Insurer acceptance and active applicable coverage

Equipment readiness and operating permissions

Orientation, pay terms, contacts, and first assignment

RELEASE or HOLD decision, reviewer, date, and open items

# Worksheet 5 | Pre-purchase decision

Mark each item READY, HOLD, or NOT APPLICABLE with a reason. An important unresolved prerequisite means HOLD; this is not a points system.

I can explain the business model and source of workable freight.

My all-mile cost model and cash forecast survive a disruption.

I have written insurance guidance for the actual operation.

The recruiting test produced credible evidence of candidate fit.

Candidate timing, qualification steps, and alternatives are clear.

Equipment condition and full acquisition costs are understood.

Registration, coverage, delivery, and hiring timing are coordinated.

Cash reserves remain available after purchase commitments.

Decision, reasons, responsible owner, and next review date

# Conclusion: Build the business before buying the truck

A driver is a professional choosing a job. A truck is equipment chosen to perform work. Your responsibility is to bring the work, the person, the equipment, and the money together in a way that can operate safely and continue paying its bills.

Start with three actions. Write the actual job on one page. Build the all-mile cost and weekly cash models. Run a measured recruiting test with an honest description and a named person answering candidates. Those actions will reveal more than another afternoon looking at truck listings.

If the answers are weak, improve the plan. If they are strong, complete the remaining launch work and make the purchase decision with evidence. If you already bought equipment, use the same discipline to recover control. The order matters because each step tests the assumptions behind the next.

Freight University exists in this book as the place to begin learning. Official agencies, qualified advisers, written quotes, and your own operating records complete the picture. Keep learning after the first hire and after the first load.

The goal is not simply to own a truck. The goal is to build an operation worth owning.

# Sources and research notes

Sources checked October 30, 2026. Linked source IDs in the text open the corresponding reference. Requirements and platform terms can change; verify the current rule before use.

S1 FTC, August 28, 2024: RivX enforcement announcement. Allegations and the reported interim court action, not a general verdict about trucking investments.

Open original source

S2 FreightWaves, August 24, 2026: Trucking Downturn: Why 85% of New Carriers Did Not Survive. Attributed observation; limited methodology in the short report.

Open original source

S3 ATRI, July 1, 2025: operating-cost findings for 2024. Historical benchmark, not a current quote or a forecast for a new carrier.

Open original source

S4 FMCSA: Get Operating Authority (Docket Number). Authority types, fees, and application context.

Open original source

S5 FMCSA: New Entrant Safety Assurance Program. Monitoring, audit, and safety-management context.

Open original source

S6 FMCSA: Summary of Hours of Service Regulations. Review the full applicable rules, exceptions, and operating context.

Open original source

S7 Indeed employer guidance: How Pricing Works on Indeed. Verify the account-specific pricing and controls before spending.

Open original source

S8 FMCSA: Entry-Level Driver Training. Covered applicants, exceptions, and Training Provider Registry.

Open original source

S9 49 CFR 391.21: Application for employment. Required information and the additional relevant employment-history provisions.

Open original source

S10 49 CFR 391.23: Investigation and inquiries. Driving-record and safety-history inquiries, timing, and related processes.

Open original source

S11 49 CFR 391.51: Driver qualification files. File contents, medical-record provisions, annual-review records, and retention.

Open original source

S12 FMCSA Pre-Employment Screening Program: FAQs. Voluntary participation and driver authorization requirements.

Open original source

S13 FMCSA Clearinghouse: Queries and Consent Requests FAQs. Full pre-employment queries, annual queries, and follow-up.

Open original source

S14 FMCSA: Pre-Employment Testing. Negative-result requirements and delayed-start/re-employment guidance.

Open original source

S15 FTC and EEOC: Background Checks: What Employers Need to Know. General disclosure, permission, and adverse-action guidance.

Open original source

## Research decisions

Unsupported universal failure rates, universal idle-truck losses, fixed agency-price claims, demographic assertions, fine schedules, and a generic repossession countdown were not carried into this book. The 85% report is qualified. Financial examples and case stories are expressly illustrative. The 2024 ATRI figure is identified as historical; a later secondary report was not substituted for a primary source table. Freight University course availability was not independently confirmed.